

RRB NTPC Graduate Level Exam

General Awareness — 20 Premium High-Yield MCQs with Detailed Explanations

Q1. Indus Valley Civilization (Advanced Architecture)

Which Indus Valley Civilization site uniquely features a tripartite division of city planning (Upper Town, Middle Town, and Lower Town) instead of the standard bipartite (Citadel and Lower Town) division?

- A) Harappa
- B) Kalibangan
- C) Dholavira
- D) Mohenjo-daro

Correct Answer: C) Dholavira

Target Trend: Graduate Level Predictive Question

Explanation: Unlike standard Harappan cities divided into two segments (Citadel and Lower Town), Dholavira features an advanced tripartite layout (Upper, Middle, and Lower towns) fortified heavily with massive stone architecture. Located in Gujarat, it is also internationally celebrated for its elaborate network of 16 grand rock-cut water reservoirs.

Q2. Mauryan Empire & Epigraphy (Edicts)

Which of the following minor rock edicts of Emperor Ashoka explicitly mentions his personal name 'Ashoka', instead of his usual royal title 'Devanampriya Priyadarsi'?

- A) Maski Edict
- B) Bhabru Edict
- C) Rummindei Pillar Edict
- D) Kalinga Rock Edict

Correct Answer: A) Maski Edict

Target Trend: Graduate Level Predictive Question

Explanation: Out of thousands of carved inscriptions across ancient India, Emperor Ashoka consistently styled himself as 'Devanampriya' (Beloved of Gods) or 'Priyadarsi'. The discovery of the Maski Edict in 1915 (Karnataka) uniquely carved his actual name 'Asoka', allowing historians to definitively unlock his identity as the author of all pan-subcontinental decrees.

Q3. Mauryan Empire & Archeological Heritage (Current Affairs Hybrid)

The Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) initiated a major conservation project to uncover the historic 80-pillared Mauryan assembly hall at the heritage site of Kumhrar (Patna). This structural marvel serves as prime archaeological proof of the imperial palace system of ancient Pataliputra. Historically, this assembly hall is famously associated with which milestone event during Emperor Ashoka's reign?

- A) The signing of the peace treaty with Seleucus Nicator
- B) The coronation ceremony of Chandragupta Maurya
- C) The convening of the Third Buddhist Council
- D) The formal appointment of the first Dhamma Mahamatras

Correct Answer: C) The convening of the Third Buddhist Council

Target Trend: New Board Pattern (Current Affairs + Core Ancient History Hybrid)

Explanation: The 80-pillared polished sandstone hall at Kumhrar represents the pinnacle of Mauryan administrative architecture. Archaeologists and historical texts outline that it was within this grand capital assembly hall that Emperor Ashoka convened the Third Buddhist Council to purify the Buddhist Sangha and settle administrative differences. The pillars are made of premium Chunar sandstone exhibiting the mirror-like signature Mauryan polish.

Q4. Buddhism & Cultural Heritage (UNESCO Milestone)

In July 2026, the "Ancient Buddhist Site of Sarnath" in Uttar Pradesh was officially inscribed as India's 45th UNESCO World Heritage Property during the 48th Session of the World Heritage Committee. Sarnath is universally revered in ancient Indian history as the location for which pivotal event in the life of Gautama Buddha?

- A) Mahabhinishkramana (The Great Renunciation)
- B) Sambodhi (Attaining Supreme Enlightenment)
- C) Dhammacakkappavattana (The Turning of the Wheel of Law)
- D) Mahaparinirvana (The Ultimate Passing Away)

Correct Answer: C) Dhammacakkappavattana (The Turning of the Wheel of Law)

Target Trend: New Board Pattern (Current Affairs + Core Ancient History Hybrid)

Explanation: After attaining enlightenment under the Peepal tree in Bodh Gaya, Gautama Buddha travelled to the Isipatana Deer Park in Sarnath. It was here that he delivered his first sermon to his initial five disciples. This historic act is called Dhammacakkappavattana, establishing the core Buddhist Sangha. The newly inscribed property includes the Dhamekh Stupa, the Chaukhandi Stupa, and the legendary Ashokan Lion Capital Pillar.

Q5. Post-Gupta Era & Tripartite Struggle

Which Rashtrakuta monarch built the world-famous monolithic rock-cut Kailashnath Temple at Ellora (Cave 16) by cutting an entire hillside from the top down?

- A) Dantidurga
- B) Amoghavarsha I
- C) Krishna I
- D) Dhruva Dharavarsha

Correct Answer: C) Krishna I

Target Trend: Graduate Level Predictive Question

Explanation: Carved straight from the top of a basalt hillside down instead of piling separate structural stones, Cave 16's monolithic Kailashnath Temple at Ellora remains an engineering marvel. It was commissioned and executed under the direct royal patronage of the 8th-century Rashtrakuta King Krishna I.

Q6. Jainism & Tirthankara Lineages

Consider the following statements regarding the early Tirthankaras of Jainism:

- (A) The holy city of Ayodhya is traditionally recognized as the birthplace of the first Tirthankara, Rishabhdev.
- (B) Ayodhya is also celebrated as the birthplace of the fourth Tirthankara, Abhinandannath.
- (C) The ancient city of Varanasi is historically recorded as the birthplace of both the first and the fourth Tirthankaras.

Which of the statement(s) given above is/are CORRECT?

- A) (A) and (B) only
- B) (B) only
- C) (A) and (C) only
- D) (A), (B) and (C)

Correct Answer: A) (A) and (B) only

Sourced From: SSC CGL 2025 Core PYQ

Explanation: According to Jain canonical texts, Ayodhya holds a monumental status as the birthplace of five distinct Tirthankaras, including the 1st (Rishabhdev / Adinatha) and the 4th (Abhinandannath). Varanasi is not the birthplace of the first or fourth Tirthankara; instead, it is historically revered as the birthplace of the 23rd Tirthankara, Parshvanatha, along with the 7th and 11th Tirthankaras.

Q7. Vedic Philosophy (Upanishadic Texts)

The celebrated Mahavakya (great saying) 'Tat Tvam Asi' (Thou Art That), which establishes the absolute identity between the individual soul and the cosmic reality, occurs in which Upanishad?

- A) Mundaka Upanishad
- B) Chandogya Upanishad
- C) Katha Upanishad
- D) Brihadaranyaka Upanishad

Correct Answer: B) Chandogya Upanishad

Sourced From: BPSC Prelims

Explanation: While standard papers repeatedly quiz Satyameva Jayate (Mundaka Upanishad), graduate papers test profound philosophical axioms. 'Tat Tvam Asi' is embedded inside the Chandogya Upanishad (Sama Veda), mapping the ultimate metaphysical non-dualism of the soul and the supreme reality.

Q8. Ancient Revenue Administration (Fiscal Terminology)

In the context of Mauryan and Gupta administrative records, what did the term 'Vishti' refer to?

- A) A religious tax levied on pilgrims
- B) Forced or unpaid labor extracted by the state
- C) An emergency tax imposed during wartime
- D) The crown land directly supervised by the king

Correct Answer: B) Forced or unpaid labor extracted by the state

Sourced From: MPPSC Prelims

Explanation: In ancient land and fiscal charters, Vishti denoted state-mandated forced labor. Citizens or local villagers were legally bound to render free physical labor to advance state infrastructure, forge fortresses, or handle heavy baggage movements for the marching imperial army, a practice peaking extensively under the Guptas.

Q9. Indus Valley Civilization (Great Bath)

The famous "Great Bath" (Vishal Snanagar), which served as a large public pool for ritual bathing, was excavated at which of the following Indus Valley Civilization sites?

- A) Harappa
- B) Lothal
- C) Mohenjo-daro
- D) Kalibangan

Correct Answer: C) Mohenjo-daro

Sourced From: UPSSSC & State SSC Exams

Explanation: The Great Bath is located on the fortified Citadel mound of Mohenjo-daro. It features a sophisticated rectangular tank engineered with finely fitted bricks and sealed with natural bitumen (tar) to make it waterproof. Historians conclude it was reserved for unique public purification or ritual bathing events rather than recreational swimming.

Q10. Buddhism (The First Sermon)

At which sacred place did Gautama Buddha deliver his very first sermon, historically known as 'Dhammacakkappavattana' (Turning the Wheel of Law)?

- A) Kushinagar
- B) Sarnath
- C) Bodh Gaya
- D) Shravasti

Correct Answer: B) Sarnath

Sourced From: UPPSC & BPSC Prelims

Explanation: Following his spiritual enlightenment at Bodh Gaya, Gautama Buddha journeyed to the Isipatana Deer Park in Sarnath. There, he delivered his foundational discourse to his first five disciples, outlining the core philosophy of Buddhism: the Four Noble Truths and the Eightfold Path (Asthangika Marga).

Q11. Mauryan Empire (The Royal Ambassador)

Megasthenes, the celebrated Greek ethnographer and historian who authored the ancient book 'Indica', visited India as a royal ambassador in the court of which Maurya ruler?

- A) Chandragupta Maurya
- B) Bindusara
- C) Ashoka
- D) Dasharatha Maurya

Correct Answer: A) Chandragupta Maurya

Sourced From: SSC CGL & WBCS Prelims

Explanation: Megasthenes was dispatched to the Mauryan imperial capital of Pataliputra by the Hellenistic King Seleucus I Nicator. His textual compilation, Indica, served as the primary Western historical window into early Indian governance, detailed municipal committee structures, and the unique sociological distribution of the population.

Q12. Post-Mauryan Rulers (The Saka Era)

The Saka Era, which forms the definitive framework for the National Calendar of India today, was officially founded by which ruler?

- A) Vikramaditya
- B) Chandragupta I
- C) Kanishka
- D) Rudradaman I

Correct Answer: C) Kanishka

Sourced From: MPSC & State Police SI Exams

Explanation: The Saka Era was officially established by the Kushana Emperor Kanishka in 78 CE to mark his imperial coronation. Owing to its historical accuracy and deep integration across regions, it was formally adapted by the Government of India in 1957 as the baseline configuration for the official Indian National Calendar.

Q13. Gupta Epigraphy (The Court Eulogy)

The historic Prayag Prashasti (Allahabad Pillar Inscription), which serves as a major biographical record detailing the massive military conquests of Emperor Samudragupta, was composed by his court poet:

- A) Harisena
- B) Banabhatta
- C) Kalidasa
- D) Ravikirti

Correct Answer: A) Harisena

Sourced From: GPSC & CGPSC Prelims

Explanation: The Prayag Prashasti is a royal Sanskrit eulogy beautifully drafted by Samudragupta's court poet and minister, Harisena. Engraved cleanly onto an existing sandstone Ashokan pillar in Allahabad, it lists the specific kingdoms systematically annexed or subdued by Samudragupta across both Northern and Southern India.

Q14. Indus Valley Civilization (Exceptional Layout Architecture)

Which of the following is the only major Indus Valley Civilization city that was discovered completely without a Citadel (fortified upper town area)?

- A) Kalibangan
- B) Banawali
- C) Chanhudaro
- D) Lothal

Correct Answer: C) Chanhudaro

Sourced From: SSC MTS & CGL Transferred PYQ

Explanation: Chanhudaro (located in Sindh, Pakistan) is the only major Harappan settlement that entirely lacks a fortified citadel structure. It functioned primarily as a busy industrial craft hub completely dedicated to bead-making factories, shell-cutting workshops, seal-carving, and cosmetic tool manufacturing.

Q15. Vedic Rituals & Lifecycle Education System

In the Vedic period, which solemn ritual/sacred ceremony marked the official entry of a student into formal education and spiritual training under a Guru?

- A) Upanayana
- B) Grihastha
- C) Vanaprastha
- D) Niyoga

Correct Answer: A) Upanayana

Sourced From: SSC CHSL & MTS Transferred PYQ

Explanation: The Upanayana Sanskar (Sacred Thread Ceremony) signified a spiritual initiation for a child in the Vedic era. It marked the formal conclusion of early childhood and the official structural transition into the Brahmacharya Ashram—the lifelong student phase dedicated to acquiring secular and metaphysical knowledge at a Gurukul.

Q16. Indian Drainage System & Geopolitics (Indus Waters Treaty)

The Kishanganga Hydroelectric Project, which has been a major point of contention between India and Pakistan under the Indus Waters Treaty, is built on a tributary of which river?

- A) Chenab
- B) Jhelum
- C) Ravi
- D) Indus

Correct Answer: B) Jhelum

Sourced From: UPPCS Prelims & UKPSC Target Framework

Explanation: The Kishanganga River is a direct right-bank tributary of the Jhelum River (referred to as the Neelum River in Pakistan). Because of its crucial position near the Line of Control and the terms governing water flow under the 1960 Indus Waters Treaty, its hydro-infrastructure management holds massive geopolitical and tactical significance.

Q17. Geomorphology of the Brahmaputra (The Namcha Barwa Syntax)

The Yarlung Tsangpo River (Brahmaputra) flows eastward parallel to the Himalayas in Tibet. Upon reaching which specific geographical feature does it take a sharp U-turn (syntaxial bend) to enter India through Arunachal Pradesh?

- A) Kanchenjunga
- B) Namcha Barwa
- C) Nanda Devi
- D) Kamet

Correct Answer: B) Namcha Barwa

Target Trend: Graduate Level Predictive Question (State PSC Adaptation)

Explanation: The Brahmaputra creates a deep, dramatic gorge by executing a sudden 180-degree turn right around the Namcha Barwa peak (7,782m) at the easternmost edge of the Himalayan arc. It enters India through this deep structural gorge under the name Dihang or Siang.

Q18. Himalayan River Nomenclature (Regional Profiles)

Which Himalayan river, originating near Mount Kailash and flowing through the Tibet Autonomous Region, is locally known as 'Langchen Khambab' (meaning the Elephant River) before cutting across the Indian borders?

- A) Indus River
- B) Sutlej River
- C) Brahmaputra River
- D) Ghaghara River

Correct Answer: B) Sutlej River

Sourced From: SSC CGL 2025 Tier-1 (September Shift)

Explanation: The Sutlej River, which enters India through the Shipki La pass after originating near Rakas Tal/Mansarovar, is natively referred to as 'Langchen Khambab' (Elephant River) inside Tibet due to local geographic traditions. In comparison, the Indus River is known as 'Singi Khamban' (Lion's Mouth) and the Brahmaputra as the 'Yarlung Tsangpo'.

Q19. Advanced Tectonic & Ecological Lake Features

Consider the following statements regarding major lakes situated within the Himalayan drainage ecosystem:

1. Wular Lake, the largest freshwater lake in India, was formed primarily due to tectonic activity and is structurally fed and regulated by the Jhelum River.
2. Loktak Lake in Northeast India is characterized by Phumdis (floating masses of vegetation and soil) and hosts the world's only floating national park.
3. Pangong Tso is a high-altitude freshwater lake formed purely by glacial blockages in the trans-Himalayan belt.

Which of the statements given above are CORRECT?

- A) 1 and 3 only
- B) 2 and 3 only
- C) 1 and 2 only
- D) 1, 2, and 3

Correct Answer: C) 1 and 2 only

Target Trend: Graduate Level Predictive Question (State PSC Adaptation)

Explanation: Statement 1 is correct: Wular lake's basin was created by plate-tectonic depressions, and it is directly fed and drained by the course of the Jhelum River. Statement 2 is correct: Loktak features floating Phumdis which support the Keibul Lamjao National Park (the last refuge of the endangered Sangai deer). Statement 3 is incorrect: Pangong Tso is an endorheic, landlocked saline/brackish water lake, not a freshwater lake, due to high mineral concentrations and evaporation rates in the cold desert of Ladakh.

Q20. Strategic Hydropower and Himalayan Border Hydrology (Current Affairs Hybrid)

Consider the following statements regarding the dynamic river infrastructure projects in the eastern Himalayan region that have been in the news recently:

1. The Lohit River, a major left-bank tributary of the Brahmaputra River, has been a key area of focus for massive strategic infrastructure and hydroelectric project development along the India-China border.
2. The Rangeet River, which hosts a prominent operating concrete gravity dam, is the largest perennial tributary of the Teesta River and originates from the glaciers of the Kanchenjunga region.
3. The famous Bhupen Hazarika Bridge (Dhola–Sadiya Bridge), India's longest water bridge, is constructed across the main channel of the Subansiri River to connect Assam and Arunachal Pradesh.

Which of the statements given above are CORRECT?

- A) 1 and 3 only
- B) 2 and 3 only
- C) 1 and 2 only
- D) 1, 2, and 3

Correct Answer: C) 1 and 2 only

Target Trend: New Board Pattern (Current Affairs + Core Geography Hybrid)

Explanation: Statement 1 is CORRECT: The Lohit River is a major left-bank tributary of the Brahmaputra. Due to its strategic proximity to the international border, it has been heavily featured in recent defense and greenfield hydroelectric construction infrastructure negotiations to secure India's border utilities. Statement 2 is CORRECT: The Rangeet River originates from the Kabru glacier in the lower Kanchenjunga region, serves as a key boundary line between Sikkim and the Darjeeling district of West Bengal, and merges as the principal tributary into the turbulent Teesta River. Statement 3 is INCORRECT: The Bhupen Hazarika Bridge is constructed across the Lohit River, not the Subansiri River.